CONCEPT PAPER

Land + Launch NWA

A Global Innovation Sharing Initiative

An innovation sharing initiative connecting global founders to the industries that anchor Northwest Arkansas — commerce enablement, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation. Led by the Greater Bentonville Area Chamber of Commerce. Delivered by Arkade.

DOCUMENT TYPE	UPDATED	GRANT REQUEST
DRAFT CONCEPT PAPER	APRIL 2026	~$1.5M (3 YEARS)

Executive Summary

Northwest Arkansas (NWA) is home to one of the most concentrated industry ecosystems in the world.

Five global headquarters anchor the region's core industries, including consumer commerce (Walmart, Sam's Club), food and agriculture (Tyson Foods, Simmons Foods), and logistics and transportation (J.B. Hunt), alongside more than 1,100 CPG brand offices. Three of those companies — Walmart, Tyson Foods, and J.B. Hunt — rank in the Fortune 500. Combined annual revenue from NWA-headquartered companies exceeds **$750 billion**, more than the GDP of metropolitan Boston. For a region of just over 600,000 residents, that's a rare concentration of industry and an exceptional ratio of size to economic gravity.

$750B+	**5**	**1,100+**
annual revenue from NWA-HQ companies	global headquarters across anchor industries	CPG brand offices in the region

While Northwest Arkansas has made meaningful progress in supporting early-stage entrepreneurs' access to capital and startup development, there is currently a gap in connecting founders and talent into large-scale industry environments and applied innovation opportunities. Startups all over the world want access to NWA's industry ecosystem, and the region's founders, students, and industry decision makers want access to global innovation, the companies, ideas, and capital building the next generation of commerce enablement, food, and logistics. Without intentional channels for innovation, knowledge, and talent exchange, that mutual interest does not consistently translate into sustained engagement, meaningful partnerships, or long-term regional impact.

The Greater Bentonville Area Chamber of Commerce, in partnership with Arkade, proposes a three-year initiative to build that ecosystem by creating programming that connects global and local entrepreneurs, expands access to industry knowledge, and builds pathways for talent. Land + Launch NWA will be administered by the Chamber as fiduciary partner and delivered through Arkade's platform supporting founder engagement and ecosystem connectivity.

This effort will:

- Engage B2B technology startups, based globally and locally, serving commerce enablement, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation
- Connect founders and teams to NWA's industry ecosystem of mentors, advisors, leaders, talent, and partners
- Strengthen regional innovation programming and gatherings open to cohort participants and the broader community
- Expand access to opportunity for founders, students, and workforce participants in Northwest Arkansas
- Elevate Bentonville's national and global profile as a hub for applied industry innovation and talent

We are seeking **$1.5 million** in catalytic grant funding, matched by approximately **$822,000** in private and in-kind contributions from Arkade and the Chamber over three years. Grant funding will support four key components: Ecosystem Intelligence and Strategic Positioning, Partnership Engagement and Cohort Curation, Innovation Programming and Industry Gatherings, and Talent and Ecosystem Integration.

The Challenge: Opportunity Without Connection

Today, the two-way exchange between NWA's local ecosystem and the global innovation community is limited, leaving founders, students, decision makers, and higher education institutions without consistent channels of access.

How this plays out today:

- Companies from outside the region conduct cold outreach or visit Bentonville for 1–2 days of meetings, then leave
- Introductions are made informally, without structure or sustained follow-through
- No formalized programming connects founders to workspace, pilot opportunities, regulatory navigation, or workforce
- High-growth companies default to Austin, Atlanta, New York, and Toronto — ecosystems that actively attract and integrate them

Entrepreneurs often face challenges in accessing:

- Warm introductions and relationship-building access to local industry leadership
- Coordinated entry points into the regional talent ecosystem
- Opportunities to engage with applied innovation at scale and peers building across geographies

Students and early-career professionals locally would benefit from increased access to:

- Hands-on experience with innovation-driven companies
- Exposure to emerging technologies and entrepreneurial pathways
- Networking access to local business and commercial leadership

> Without intentional channels for innovation, knowledge, and talent exchange, the region risks underutilizing its full innovation potential. When global and local builders and decision makers connect through Land + Launch NWA, everyone in the community wins through employment, idea exchange, and ecosystem growth.

The Solution: Land + Launch NWA

Program Overview

Land + Launch NWA is an annual cohort-based initiative supporting growth-stage B2B technology companies building in Northwest Arkansas' anchor industries: consumer commerce, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation. **Growth-stage** is defined here as companies at Series A+ with demonstrated product-market fit in their native markets.

The six-month program offers each cohort of **six to 12 startup companies** support through transition and cultural education, a home-based work site with built-in industry-related peers, and access to top leaders and students through events and programming.

Participating companies benefit from:

- Targeted, personalized introductions to ecosystem partners, mentors, investors, and industry leaders
- Programming, workshops, and learning opportunities across commerce enablement, food, and logistics
- Engagement with student talent and higher public education institutions
- A dedicated desk and physical workspace at Arkade in the Ledger Building
- Legal, regulatory, and relocation navigation through Chamber of Commerce resources and Arkade's advisory board

> **Land + Launch NWA is built around the entrepreneurs themselves** — providing the workspace, programming, mentorship, and ecosystem connections they need to explore Northwest Arkansas as a long-term fit and build the relationships that make a sustained presence meaningful.

Target Company Profile

- A mix of founders building from outside the region (75%) and Northwest Arkansas-based founders building for anchor industries (25%)
- B2B technology companies in NWA's anchor industries — commerce enablement, food and agriculture, logistics and transportation, AI and data analytics, automation and robotics, and sustainability and packaging
- Series A+ with demonstrated product-market fit, revenue generating or in late-stage pilot phase
- Capacity to hire locally within 12 months
- Companies actively seeking to engage with the NWA ecosystem

Four Pillars of Programming

01 Ecosystem Intelligence and Strategic Positioning

THE FOUNDATION LAYER

Strengthen understanding of the regional innovation landscape and identify opportunities for the exchange of innovation, knowledge, and talent — connecting global founders, local entrepreneurs, students, and industry.

Grant-supported Activities

- Subscribe to research, sourcing, and network tools (data subscriptions)
- Conduct ecosystem mapping and landscape analysis across NWA's anchor industries
- Develop sector-specific insights across commerce enablement, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation
- Identify and map founders and investors
- Maintain impact dashboarding and reporting

02 Partnership Engagement and Cohort Curation

THE ENGAGEMENT LAYER

Connect with global and local founder networks and bring high-potential founders into the Northwest Arkansas innovation ecosystem experience — building cohorts that strengthen mutual exchange between the region and the broader innovation community.

Grant-supported Activities

- Hire a dedicated founder network and ecosystem engagement lead
- Cultivate partnerships across regional organizations and institutions (i.e., form a local Brand Leadership Council)
- Engage partners from embassy, trade, and accelerators
- Connect with higher education networks and global innovation communities
- Perform targeted outreach campaigns across commerce enablement, food, and logistics channels

Four Pillars of Programming

03 Innovation Programming and Industry Gatherings

THE COLLABORATION LAYER

Create consistent opportunities for the exchange of innovation, knowledge, and talent — bringing global founders, local entrepreneurs, students, and industry leaders together for learning, collaboration, and ecosystem participation.

Grant-supported Activities

- **Bentonville Market Immersion Week** (1× each company) — A 2–4 day welcome itinerary with team orientation, minimum of 5 warm intro meetings to local leaders or potential customers, and tours across restaurants, museums, trails, and the Bentonville campus.
- **Industry Education Workshops** (monthly) — Curated 10-person lunches or workshops discussing demand-driven innovation topics across commerce enablement, food, and logistics; with a focus on what works locally and culturally for businesses in Bentonville.
- **BiteSized Conference with Industry Decision Makers** (quarterly) — Closed-door, curated discussions between global and local founders, enterprise executives, and industry investors; with a focus on partnership acceleration and ecosystem alignment.
- **Access to Arkade and Chamber Ecosystem Events** (roundtables, networking lunches, forums, and summits) throughout program, including the Regional Tech Summit — a high-visibility gathering hosted by the Chamber and produced in partnership with Arkade. Includes global founder showcases, industry innovation panels, strategy sessions, media engagement, and talent engagement programming.
- **Relationship Curation** (throughout program) — Connections to industry leaders, enterprise partners, investors, and talent across the cohort experience.
- **Pilot Facilitation** (as opportunities arise) — Implementation support for cohort companies entering pilot relationships with industry partners.

Four Pillars of Programming

04 Talent and Ecosystem Integration

THE COMPOUNDING LAYER

Expand access for Northwest Arkansas students, early-career professionals, and workforce participants to engage with innovation across commerce enablement, food, and logistics, while supporting companies as they build enduring local impact through knowledge exchange and community participation.

Grant-supported Activities

Talent Pathways

- **Innovation Fellows program** — paid internships placing students and early-career professionals within cohort and Arkade member companies for hands-on exposure to growth-stage innovation
- **Curriculum and degree pathway collaboration** — partnering with educators at the University of Arkansas, Northwest Arkansas Community College, and other higher education institutions to inform what's taught to students
- **Visibility and invitations** — targeted communications inviting Northwest Arkansas talent groups to participate in Pillar 3 programming, panels, workshops, and gatherings
- **Featured speaking and learning opportunities** — active engagement of Northwest Arkansas talent within Pillar 3 events as speakers, panelists, and learners
- **Warm introductions for talent** — connecting Northwest Arkansas talent to globally-based cohort companies, mirroring the relationship curation offered to cohort startups in Pillar 3

Operational & Transition Support

- Provide legal and regulatory navigation
- Support entity formation
- Guide visa and relocation (1× each company)
- Facilitate community integration
- Make investor introductions
- Develop local media content and engagement

Governance and Measurable Outcomes

Governance & Structure

To ensure compliance, transparency, and alignment with philanthropic best practices:

- The Greater Bentonville Chamber of Commerce will serve as fiduciary
- All grant funds will be administered through the Chamber
- Funds will be allocated strictly toward approved programmatic activities
- Arkade will serve as program delivery partner under a formal agreement
- Clear KPIs and quarterly reporting will be established
- Annual public impact reporting will be produced

Chamber leads on:

- Grant administration and compliance
- Regional ecosystem alignment and partnerships
- Civic and corporate introductions and engagement opportunities
- Community engagement and reporting
- Economic impact monitoring

Arkade leads on:

- Program delivery and founder engagement
- Cohort sourcing and engagement strategy execution
- Company relationship management
- Ecosystem introduction coordination
- Outcome tracking and reporting

Measurable Outcomes (Over 3 Years)

The initiative will track outcomes across two categories: direct program and ecosystem engagement, and broader economic indicators resulting from ecosystem investment, with quarterly reporting to the Chamber.

Program and Ecosystem Engagement

- 25–30 growth-stage companies supported through formal cohort programming
- 100+ ecosystem introductions facilitated, including connections to advisors, operators, mentors, talent, and potential partners
- 75+ programming touchpoints with entrepreneurs annually engaged across workshops, roundtables, conferences, and gatherings that are open to the broader community
- 15–20 students placed through the Innovation Fellows program (University of Arkansas VIP program partnership)
- 3+ educational partnerships established with regional institutions, including pathways such as internship pipelines, guest programming, applied research collaborations, and career pathway exposure for students. Institutions may include NWACC, John Brown University, University of Arkansas, Bentonville-area School Districts, Ignite Entrepreneurship Programs, and future STEM University.

Broader Economic Indicators

The initiative will also track broader economic indicators resulting from ecosystem engagement:

- Jobs created in Northwest Arkansas by participating companies
- Capital attracted to the region by participating founders

- Pilot programs launched through program introductions across commerce enablement, food, and logistics
- Companies establishing a sustained operating presence in the region

> These outcomes focus on strengthening participation, expanding access to opportunity, and deepening ecosystem connectivity, with economic returns tracked and reported as natural byproducts of community investment.

Budget, Cost Share, and Sustainability Model

Budget Overview (3-Year Total: ~$2.3M)

$1.5M	$822K	$2.3M
Grant Request	Arkade + Chamber Match	Total Program Budget

Major Budget Categories

Personnel: Head of Global Innovation Growth · Member Education & Programming Manager · Partial allocation: Director of Portfolio Operations · Contracted event coordination

Program Infrastructure: Workspace allocation · Research, sourcing, and network tools · Channel marketing support

Events & Gatherings: Quarterly BiteSized conferences · Monthly ecosystem programming · Regional Tech Summit production

Travel & Outreach: International and domestic outreach travel · Key industry events and conferences · Inbound programming travel support

Administration: 10–15% program administration allocation · Fiscal oversight through Chamber

Cost Share & Sustainability Model

This initiative is catalytic funding designed for long-term sustainability — tapering over three years toward earned revenue, corporate sponsorship, and sustained ecosystem support.

YEAR 1 — LAUNCH	YEAR 2 — SCALE	YEAR 3 — SUSTAIN
100%	**65 / 35**	**30 / 70**
Grant — build infrastructure and engage first cohort	Grant / Match — expand programming and grow earned revenue	Grant / Earned Revenue + Sponsorship + Match — transition to self-sustaining model

Long-term sustainability mechanisms

- Company participation fees
- Corporate sponsorship
- Event and programming revenue
- Regional ecosystem development support

The Proven Model: Regional Comparables

This kind of ecosystem programming is not an untested concept — it is an established and growing category of regional investment that has produced measurable community and economic returns in comparable metros across the U.S. and internationally.

Opportunity Austin / Global Launch Pad (Austin, TX)

Backed by the Austin Chamber of Commerce — structurally the most direct analog to what Arkade and the Chamber are proposing — Austin's program has contributed to **400+ international companies** now operating in the region. Austin is the most direct U.S. market competitor to NWA for attracting growth-stage technology companies. The fact that Austin has formalized a Chamber-backed ecosystem program while NWA has not is a competitive risk this initiative directly addresses.

Georgia Tech Enterprise Innovation Institute (Atlanta, GA)

Since launching in 2018, Georgia Tech's cohort-based program has achieved a **68% U.S. expansion rate** — 15 of 22 participating international companies successfully expanded into the U.S. market. This compares to an industry average of approximately 30% for informal market entry, demonstrating that structured programming — not just introductions — is the decisive variable in conversion.

Toronto Global (Toronto, Ontario)

The closest operational model to what Arkade and the Chamber are proposing, at a larger scale. Over its history, Toronto Global has facilitated **260 structured engagements** generating **33,000+ jobs** and **$1.3 billion CAD in cumulative community tax impact**. In 2023/24 alone, 44 structured engagements produced 5,527 jobs and $217.5M CAD in tax impact. These numbers establish that ecosystem investment programs deliver meaningful community and economic returns over time.

> **The bottom line:** NWA has everything those metros have — and in commerce enablement, food, and logistics, considerably more. What has been missing is the infrastructure to connect that advantage to opportunity. This initiative builds it.

The Partnership and Why This Matters Now

The Partnership

Two organizations. Each essential. One shared mission.

This initiative is delivered through a partnership between the Greater Bentonville Area Chamber of Commerce and Arkade. The roles are distinct and complementary.

FIDUCIARY & CIVIC LEAD

Greater Bentonville Area Chamber of Commerce

The regional economic development organization and the fiduciary for the initiative. The Chamber's Bold Bentonville strategic plan explicitly names coordinated ecosystem infrastructure as a regional priority, and the Chamber operates a proven 501(c)(3) structure for public-private initiatives. This initiative aligns directly with the Chamber's stated priorities.

PROGRAM DELIVERY PARTNER

Arkade

A platform supporting founder engagement and ecosystem connectivity in Northwest Arkansas. Its work focuses on connecting global and local founders to the region's innovation ecosystem — and connecting the region's entrepreneurs to the broader global innovation community. Arkade provides workspace, programming, and curated access to advisors, industry leaders, and partners. Arkade's advisory board reflects the operators, investors, and industry leaders supporting the work.

Together, these partners contribute civic accountability and private-sector execution. Catalytic philanthropic investment makes the work possible — supporting participation, access to opportunity, and connection across Northwest Arkansas.

Why This Matters Now

Northwest Arkansas stands at a pivotal moment.

The region offers a rare concentration of global industry leadership across commerce enablement, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation, alongside major CPG presence, a growing talent pool, rapid population growth, supportive regional civic leadership, and national visibility.

Over time, this initiative makes Northwest Arkansas a community where innovation, knowledge, and talent move freely between global and local founders, students, and industry — strengthening the region for the long term.

Land + Launch NWA is the bridge that makes those connections possible.